
A Manifesto for the Profession of Architecture

Professional Practice 1

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A Manifesto for the Profession of Architecture

Architecture is **not** merely a product.

The architect is **not** a brand.

The profession is **not** a collection of market categories.

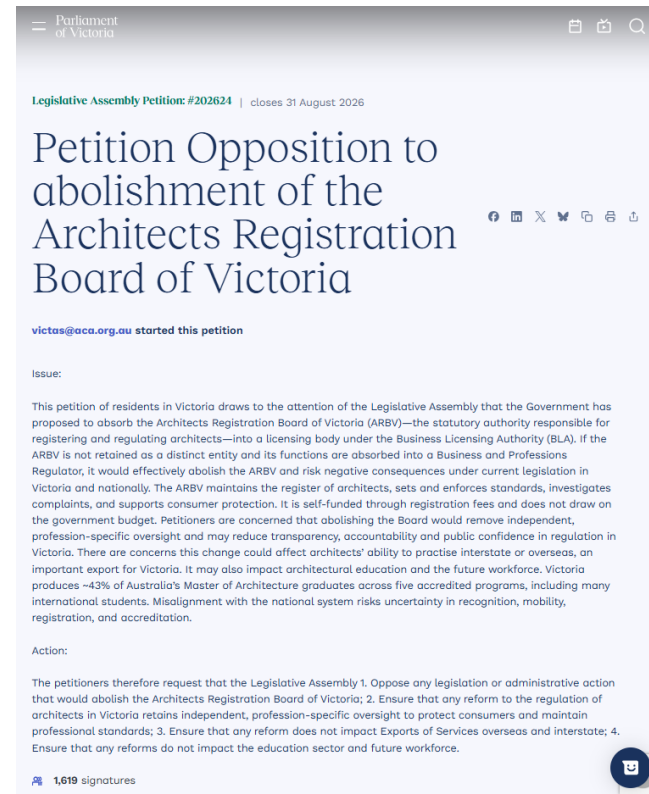
Architecture is a collective discipline entrusted to make judgements about the built environment on behalf of people—including those who cannot always be present when decisions are made.



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Education, registration and regulation are not valuable simply because they distinguish architects from others. They exist to cultivate a particular capacity: to synthesise complex knowledge, exercise professional judgement and act in the broader public interest.

If the profession cannot demonstrate this capacity, its regulation has little public purpose.



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1. Define itself by what it is **entrusted** to do, not merely by the title it holds.

Registration should articulate the particular forms of judgement society entrusts to an architect. The Act currently establishes the collective and its standards but leaves the functional meaning of the architect largely to the profession itself. This is the work on Universities, researchers and institutional bodies.

Lectures:

Models for Understanding a Profession

What has society entrusted architects to decide?



Portrait of Christopher Wren,
Godfrey Kneller, 1711

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2. Place professional **judgement**—not competency—at the centre of professional capacity

Competencies describe tasks. Professional judgement describes the ability to recognise a problem, synthesise conflicting knowledge, prioritise competing interests and make a determination in circumstances where no procedure can provide the answer.

Lectures:

Models for Understanding a Profession



The Doctor By Luke Fildes
1891

When does following the process stop being enough?

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3. Recognise the client who is **not** in the room.

An architect's obligation cannot end with the person paying the fee. Future occupants, neighbours, communities and future generations are subjects of architectural decisions.

Lectures:

*The Distinction between Architecture,
Architect and the Profession*

Models for Understanding a Profession



Remembering. Haus der Kunst
museum in Munich, Germany.
Ai Wei Wei, 2009

Who is affected by your decisions
but absent from the meeting?

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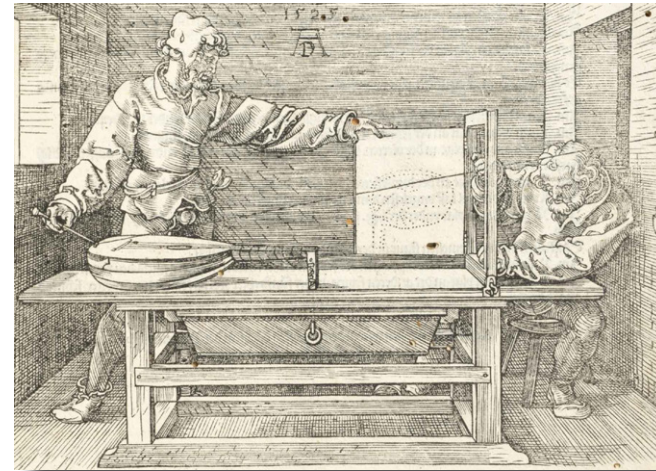
4. Treat codes, contracts and regulation as **instruments** of architecture

Architects should not understand law as something imposed upon design. Codes and contracts are descriptions of the world we collectively intend to produce. Architects should therefore participate in writing, testing and reforming them.

Lectures:

*The History of The Building Code
Contracts*

Which instrument actually
shaped this project most



Albrecht Dürer
Perspective Machines

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5. Make professional knowledge **collective.**

Knowledge produced through architectural practice should be systematically identified, tested, published, taught and incorporated into standards and regulation. Innovation that remains proprietary to an individual practice advances the company; innovation that enters disciplinary knowledge advances architecture.

Lectures:

The Good/Bad Architect.

Entrepreneur and profession.

Media + Differentiation.

Who owns architectural knowledge?



Louis XIV Visiting the Royal Academy of Sciences

,Sébastien Leclerc 1671

The French King and minister inspects a science meeting surrounded by anatomical skeleton, maps and instruments, showing state funding.

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6. Judge innovation by the public benefit it **produces** and **redistributes**.

Innovation should not be measured simply by novelty, efficiency or commercial return. The profession should ask: Who benefits? A reduction in production cost retained as company profit is commercial innovation. A method that becomes available to the profession and improves outcomes for the public is professional progress.

Lectures:

The Good/Bad Architect. Entrepreneur

Who benefits from this innovation?



Detroit Industry, by Diego Rivera, North Wall, 1932-33. Detroit Institute of Arts

Technology is celebrated only because it improves collective society.
Innovation is inseparable from labour and the public

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7. Move architectural discourse from what architecture is to **what architecture does**.

Stop defining architecture primarily through typology, aesthetics and building categories. Define it through performance, effects and the problems it is capable of addressing.

Lectures:

The Good/Bad Architect. Entrepreneur

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What does this architecture actually change?



Ambrogio Lorenzetti – Effects of Good Government 1339

The fresco depicts: trade, education, dancing, construction, farming, everyday life.

Architecture matters because of what it enables.

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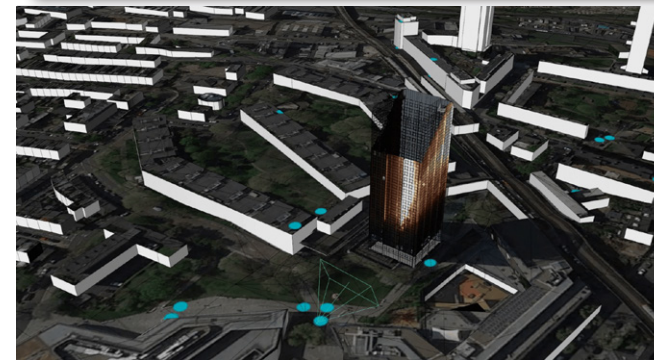
8. Stop competing through the **withdrawal** of professional responsibility.

Reduced scope and reduced fees cannot become mechanisms for progressively removing the judgement and oversight that justify the profession's regulated status. Lacrosse demonstrates the contradiction: commercial arrangements may limit services, but professional responsibility and expectations of judgement do not disappear proportionally.

Lectures:

The Distinction between Architecture,

What responsibilities have architects given away?



Forensic Architecture .org
Grenfell Media Archive: Call for footage
Architecture as evidence: expanding professional
responsibility through public-interest investigation.

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9. Rebuild the profession as a **connected and functioning** apparatus.

Universities, registration boards, institutes, practices, media and government should not operate as parallel organisations maintaining their own programs. Their purpose is to identify anomalies, contradictions and failures; commission research; test solutions; and translate knowledge into education, standards and regulation.

Is existing apparatus actually produces oversight, strategic thinking and consensus, or merely keeps “the boat afloat”.

Lectures:

The Good/Bad Architect. Entrepreneur



Zaha Hadid: 2014 Qatar World Cup Al Wakrah Stadium. Labour issues were “not my duty as an architect to look at.”



Grenfell Towers

**If this system isn't functioning,
where is it breaking down?**

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10. Measure the profession by its **contribution to the public**, not merely the success of its members

The advancement of architecture is different from the advancement of architects. Awards, media, advocacy and institutes should prioritise contributions that expand disciplinary capacity and public benefit rather than primarily celebrating individual practices.

Lectures:

The Origin of the Architects Act



"Wheatfield — A Confrontation," by Agnes Denes.
1982.

By transforming landfill in Manhattan into a wheat field. She reframed value, economy, ecology and public benefit.

What have you contributed that every architect could use